



Google for India 2024

All eyes on AI

Jayesh Shinde | jayesh@digit.in

Google's 10th 'Google for India' event had a whole host of announcements – from search to AI, among other things. It's hard to believe it's been a decade since Google kicked off this initiative, during which India's tech landscape has transformed beyond recognition. From having the world's lowest data prices to UPI revolutionising our financial transactions, India hasn't just kept pace with the digital age – it has set the tempo for innovating for the future..

Google for India 2024 wasn't just about new features or apps, but how Google plans to harness the power of AI to supercharge India's growth and address some of its most pressing challenges. Google believes so strongly about India's AI-led growth story, it has

even released a whitepaper to make its case – that India's strong AI skills, start-up ecosystem, and investment in digital transformation can drive significant economic growth and societal benefits through AI

Here are the five most important announcements from the event, and why I believe they're noteworthy....

1) Google Play Protect for side-loaded Android apps

Fraud and scams are the dark underbelly of our digital lives, and they're

only growing with every day of the week. According to the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre, Indians lost over ₹1,750 crore to cybercriminals in just the first four months of 2024. In an effort to improve Android smartphone security, Google is stepping up its game with a new pilot program that expands Google Play Protect's security capabilities. This initiative focuses on apps installed from sideloading sources – those downloaded outside the official app stores – which are often the culprits in financial fraud 95% of the time.

By analysing and automatically blocking the installation of apps requesting sensitive permissions commonly abused for fraud, Google aims to nip the problem of financial fraud in the bud. In Singapore alone, this approach has already blocked nearly 900,000 high-risk installations. For a country like India, where smartphone penetration is skyrocketing and new users are coming online every day, this could be a game-changer in protecting the most vulnerable from financial scams.

This is a crucial step, because financial fraud doesn't just affect individual victims – it ultimately erodes trust in digital platforms, which is a bigger worry. Let's see how effective this initiative is in India, but good to see Google make a concerted effort to tackle the problem.

2) Indian AI data to stay in India

Data sovereignty isn't just a buzzword, but a critical necessity – especially in

